Practical adaptation of a ritual art

MADRAS.

The auspicious yellow of turmeric, the blood-red vermilion adorning the parting of a bride's hair, the jet black of coal and the raven's wing, the deep green of verdant leaves on thick hedges, the sparkling white of lime and the brown hues of clay and dung — smeared earth... the colours of Nature and from Nature, sanctified by ceremonious usage and religious ritual: "Ariveni's" pallette is comprised of these earthy shades. The hues and symbols, which are used in the Ariveni mode of ritual painting spring from the origin of life itself for the roots of the art are seemingly buried deep in fertility rites and tantric practices.

The core of the Ariveni ritual painting, the monopoly of the potters community in the lush hills of Rishi Valley near Madanapalle (Andhra Pradesh) has been retained intact but it has been modified and adapted (without transgressing its original beauty) by transferring it on to cloth from floors and walls and given a subtle gloss through designing flair. This is presented to the urban aesthete in a practical form — bed covers, wall-hangings, cushion covers and table-cloths — at the beautiful and well-displayed exhibition of hand-embroidery at Contemporary Arts and Crafts, 6, Kasturi Estates, Madras-86 up to August 26 (10 a.m. to 6 p.m. daily).

The display is jointly presented by Milieu and the Crafts Council of India which has played a considerable role in the current renaissance of crafts in the country.

To revive a traditional art is in itself difficult. But to take the art out of the milieu and the community to which it belongs, transplant it among a group totally new to the craft and give it a contemporary look is an uphill task requiring imagination, infinite patience and a never-say-die spirit. Not to speak of the problems involved in production and marketing. Vikram Parchure, a designer in Rishi Valley, has done just that.

On a chance visit to a wedding in the village Gutlupai, more than two years ago Vikram received his first exposure to Ariveni. And the impact was instantaneous. "The pots in which the food is cooked at a wedding are considered sacrosanct. The earthen pots placed at all four corners of the wedding mantap, the floor around them and even the walls were covered with these arresting symbols and paintings which constituted worship of the Mother Goddess. At the wedding since I found only four or five symbols, I went in search of more. It took me nearly half a year to document the art from village elders. For most, it was a dead practice, the esoteric meaning of which was lost in the mists of time. But it was clear that Ariveni was deeply connected with fertility rites."

Vikram felt that in the vigour, the boldness and priemeval beauty of an unknown art, lay immense possibilities as a source of livelihood to those languishing in poverty in that area.

Vikram had initially trained as an architect and then did a course at the National Institute of Design, Ahmedabad. He was running a leather unit in Bangalore when he was forced by ill-health to sell the unit. Advised by doctors to recuperate in serene surroundings, he chose Rishi Valley. There he was drawn to the potters whose hereditary skills were rusting due to lack of proper guidance, fresh designs and above all a market.



A striking design takes shape on a cushion cover.

Vikram formed 'Milieu', a rural development project, and so successful was its interaction and training programme for potters that today they function from well-equipped and strategically located artisans collectives with a turnover of lakhs of rupees and Government grants.

"Though Ariveni too traditionally belongs to the potters community, I thought it would be better if another cross-section of rural society could benefit. Hence, I chose the field-hands from harijanwadas whose income is as low as Rs. 2.50 a day. The dozen women who had been chosen for the training programme a year ago had to be taught from the basics. Half of them dropped out as such a sedentary occupation did not suit them, used as they were to working long hours in the fields. Their diet too, sour and spicy, was oriented towards a more active life and many of them developed gastric problems and a feeling of listlessness. About five of them stuck on."

Leelavathi, a promising pupil, has accompanied Vikram to Madras for demonstrating the craft. She plans to start a cottage industry employing four or five persons. Her husband Basappa who has learnt the art of vegetable dyeing has been persuaded to assist her.

The tantric symbols or mandalas used in the paintings are generally the triangle (representing the damru of Lord Shiva), the circle (signifying the womb and the seeds of life), the square (the four directions), the ladder (the matrix) and the dot. The artist begins and ends his painting with these auspicious symbols and in between is the whole range within which the artist can play. The motifs are generally religious but sometimes floral and animal motifs are used as well.

On wall hangings however, striking figures of a finely delienated awe-inspiring Kali or a vermilion-coloured stylistic Ganesha are portrayed, since these are articles of display and not utility.

"I chose textiles for transferring the art of ritual painting as they have rotating utility — when one piece wears out, people generally want to go in for another." To retain the thick outlines resulting from the finger printing techniques in the art, thick wool-stitched edgings have been made use of while applique provides splashes of colour.

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